

Ruth Behar is an anthropology professor at the University of Michigan who is of both Ashkenazi and Sephardi Jewish heritage, was born in Cuba, and immigrated to the US as a child. Although the two chapters cover very different parts of her life, they both reflect on the tensions between being Jewish and Latina. How do these two identities interact/conflict/overlap in Behar's life? Do you see any threads of continuity between the two stories? Or are they different in important ways?

El Beso

Ruth Behar

*Todo lo que guardé se me hizo polvo;
todo lo que escondí de mis
ojos los escondí, y de mi propia vida.
Everything I hid turned to dust;
everything I hid I hid from my
own eyes, and my own life.*

DULCE MARÍA LOYNAZ, *Poemas sin nombre*

THE FIRST BOY to put his tongue in my mouth was Puerto Rican. I remember his tongue touching my tongue and then plunging down my throat so fast that I feared I would choke. I was so stunned I hardly had time to react. We were on the beach and we nearly slipped to the ground from the effort, but he managed to catch me in his arms before we both fell. The sun was low in the sky. The ocean had fallen silent. I remember his tongue was cool and that I sipped from it as if it were a fountain. He tasted of smooth sand, mint, and blooming young manhood.

I think I was twelve or thirteen; he was just two or three years older than me, but I thought of him as much, much older. And definitely more “experienced.” Boys, I was being taught by my mother, would always know more about those things than girls. Boys had to know more because they were boys. In developing into men they would need to have sex, *la cosa del hombre* required it, *no sé si entiendes, mi niña*, but they can’t hold themselves back, if they don’t have it, they will go crazy, they will explode, so don’t tempt a man, because he can’t stop himself, it’s *la cosa*, their *cosa* is like that, it’s not their fault, they have to have it, so say no, say no, remember, say no before things go too far. *Trata de entender, mi niña. No te dejes. Dí que no.* Don’t let them convince you. They don’t have anything to lose. *La que pierde es siempre la mujer. No te olvides de eso.* Wait, wait until you find *un hombre bueno, un hombre que te quiera de verdad, un hombre* who doesn’t want you just for that. *Ten cuidado*, okay? Be careful.

Lots
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mom
talked
to her
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Counterposed to this message of fearing sex and withholding from sex to save yourself for the good man who would love you enough to put a bridle on his animal needs, I would watch jealously in years to come as my father educated my brother in the ways of desire with laughter, humor, and brash joy.

On lazy Sunday mornings, after brunch, my father and my brother would lie together in bed, my father sharing with my brother his stash of *Playboys*, whose hiding place in his night table I had long since discovered. As my father looked at the pictures with my brother, he seemed to say: For you this legacy, *mi niño*. Because you are a boy, for you a taste of all the delicious fruits of a woman's body. Soon they will be yours to squeeze and smell and savor and let drip from your lips like the sweetest and juiciest of mangoes.

I don't remember how I met the Puerto Rican boy who gave me his tongue to taste. I know he was Puerto Rican from Spanish Harlem, but I don't remember his name or what he looked like, except that he was skinny and long-limbed and had thick jet-black hair. I had no idea where he was staying or who he was with. All he knew about me was that I was Cuban and lived in Queens, in upwardly mobile Forest Hills, where we'd moved recently, and that I was a chubby girl, desperately ill at ease in my red two-piece bathing suit edged with a sad blue ruffle, with eyes already cloudy from reading too many books, and so pathetically innocent about the pleasure my body was made for that it made you want to cry. We'd meet on the beach, kiss, and ask no questions.

Our kissing took place in Miami Beach, in July, when the sea grows warm as a steam bath and the hotels on Ocean Drive drop their rates by half. My parents and their friends in *El Grupo*, all Cuban Jews who had formed a tightly bonded network during the early years of immigration to New York, had begun in the late 1960s to make enough money that they felt they could afford a vacation. Someone found out that summer was the low season at the Ocean Drive hotels, whose better clients preferred to winter in the sun, and decided that the Surfcomber Hotel offered the best deal—two meals a day and two double beds and the kids stay free and a lifeguard to watch them at the pool.

Off we'd go, five *Grupo* couples and their children, to burn our skin to shreds in the cruel summer sun, drink hot pink *mamey* milkshakes, remember Cuba, and forget how hard and gray life was in New York. The *Grupo* fathers would all come for a hard-earned two weeks of vacation and then they would depart, leaving behind their bathing suits and donning their business suits to go back to work in New York and keep earning the money that allowed the *Grupo* mothers to stay for an additional two weeks in Miami Beach with the children. How free and easy were those two weeks without the fathers—no scoldings, no demands, no tensions, no arguments. How happy they looked, Miriam, Zelmi, Fanny, Nina, and my mother, lounging around the pool, their bodies slick with suntan oil, their breasts pouring jubilantly out of their bathing suits and no man to tell them, *oye, estás enseñando mucho*, their nails painted, and not a care in the world, ladies of leisure as they might have been

Fam. 14
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in Cuba had the revolution not dared to interrupt their lives so impolitely. And we *Grupo* children, how gloriously wild we were allowed to be during those fatherless two weeks, jumping in and out of the pool, no one admonishing us about how we were going to get paralyzed for not waiting long enough after eating to go swimming. It was during one of those blessed weeks when the *Grupo* mothers were alone with us that I began to learn how to kiss like a woman.

But my education was cut short. One afternoon, just after a kissing session, I climbed back to the pool area from the beach and saw my mother and brother watching me. They had strange looks on their faces, but I waved hello and tried to act nonchalant. My mother didn't waste any time getting to the point. Where had I been? Why hadn't I told her I had a boyfriend? she demanded to know. What do you mean? What boyfriend? I asked, in a vain effort to feign ignorance. Giggling at first, she said that my brother had seen me with the boy and he'd told her about it. She didn't believe him, so he said, "Okay, let's spy on Ruty," and the two of them spied on me and she saw me, saw me with her own eyes kissing the boy, clear as day. As she told me this, she broke out in a roar of laughter. Both she and my brother laughed so hard watching me, she said. It was all they could do to cover their mouths, that's how funny it was. Had I really not heard them?

I had heard nothing. Now I had heard too much. I was ashamed and angry and vowed never to trust my brother. Or my mother.

Wiping away her laughter tears, my mother asked, "*¿Quién es el muchacho?*"

Who was this boy? I hardly knew. I hardly wanted to know. "He's just a boy I met," I said.

"No parece Jewish," she said. "He doesn't seem Jewish" (about BF)

I shrugged my shoulders. "He's Puerto Rican."

"*¿Puertorriqueño? ¿Estás loca, Ruty?*" Her face became deadly serious, as if I'd just said the boy was from Mars or was contaminated with some rare form of the bubonic plague that had survived the Middle Ages. "Thank god your father isn't here," she said, putting her hand to her chest and sighing.

"And what's wrong with him being Puerto Rican? We're Cubans, aren't we?" I exclaimed, feeling very clever.

"Pero Ruty, tú que eres tan inteligente, tan smart. *¿Tú no sabes that we're Jewish?* You're too young to be kissing any boys, pero *¿cómo pudiste besar un puertorriqueño? Ay, Ruty, un puertorriqueño, ¡por tu vida! Ruty, ¿tú no sabes cómo son los puertorriqueños?* They have dirty minds. *Solamente quieren una cosa.* They want only one thing from girls. *¿Cómo te dejaste, Ruty?* And you're so smart. *No lo puedo creer. Menos mal que tu padre no está aquí. Te mata si está aquí.* Please,

Families of 11 left Cuba due to revolution
↓
Why did they all leave?
The Revolution?
Was it just due to class OR did it have something to do with being Jewish?

What does being Jewish have to do w/ the stereotypes Mom holds of Puerto Ricans?

don't ever see that boy again. If your father finds out, he'll kill me too for not stopping you."

Only later would I understand fully the depth and consequences of the prohibition my mother gave voice to that July in Miami Beach. Only later would I learn that one of my aunts, in Cuba, had run away at fifteen with a sailor who wasn't Jewish, causing my paternal grandmother to mourn and tear at her hair as if her daughter had died. Only later would I see how my grandmother looked at me with solemn eyes as I held in my lap the great-grandchild who had come of her daughter's union, for which she had so grieved. The great-grandchild had come from yet another taboo union, between her grandson and a beautiful brown Costa Rican woman. Only later would I see how my grandmother kept looking with those solemn eyes when the little girl, my cousin, brown like her mother, rose from my lap and I smoothed out the wrinkles left on my silk dress. Only later would I learn from an aunt on my mother's side of my family, who grew up in a small town in the Cuban countryside, that she'd been shipped off to Havana when her parents, my great-grandparents, the only Jews in the town, discovered that her flirtation with one of the local boys was getting "too serious." Only later would I understand how we were Cubans, yes, how we spoke Spanish, yes, and ate black beans and rice, and got nostalgic for Cuba in Miami Beach, and how, yes, we'd have ended up in Hitler's ovens had we not been saved by Cuba, but how nevertheless our belonging to the Jewish tribe made it impossible for that whole world that had nourished us and given us life to have any place in our longing, our desire, our hunger to drink from tongues and bodies that had not been branded by the yellow star. Or if we dared — as my aunt had dared — to welcome those tongues and bodies with our own tongues and bodies, then it was at the cost of bringing to the Jewish tribe unbearable suffering, grief, a loss so deep that it was unto death. Only later would I understand why I had always claimed a Latina identity so hesitantly, with such painful self-hatred, fearing that I did not deserve the love or respect of those Chicanas and Puer-torriqueñas and Cubanas who accepted me, who claimed me as one of their own, when I didn't feel worthy, because I knew, knew it in the heaviness of my heart, that I'd been brought up not to get too close to their men, not to mix with their kind, to keep separate.

I had planned to disobey my mother and keep seeing the Puerto Rican boy, somehow, secretly, when we returned to New York at the end of that July vacation in Miami Beach. In his hand I'd placed a folded piece of paper with my name and address and phone, so he'd find me, so he'd come for me from Spanish Harlem. So he'd take me away from the posh Ashkenazi Jewish neighborhood of Forest Hills, to which my father, a dark Sephardic Jew who was constantly being told he looked Puerto Rican, had moved us. Had moved me

when I'd entered my teens, trying to keep me safe from the Latino boys and black boys who were moving into our old Queens neighborhood. But the Puerto Rican boy who put his tongue in my mouth never called, never came to Forest Hills looking for me. He was forbidden fruit, which I'd never taste again.

move
was
due
to
white
flight?

Why was isolation so important
to her family?

↳ In the context of Ruth's family,
why did they believe that being Jewish
necessitate isolation? Was this
common, and, if so, why?

Focus more on a general context
instead of Ruth's family

“our belonging to the Jewish tribe made it impossible
for that
whole world ... to have any place in our
longing...” (199)

Temporary Latina

Ruth Behar

NO ONE WANTED the temporary job of acting director of Latino Studies while they searched, yet again, for a permanent director of the program. It was a humid day in early August and I was sitting with my colleagues in the program, all of us in shorts and t-shirts, around a hodgepodge of metal office tables. I had come to the meeting with some regrets, leaving my mother and my grandmother to wait for me at home. They had flown in, my mother from New York, my grandmother from Miami, for my son's fifth birthday party. We were enjoying our days together; my mother was busy stuffing my freezer with blintzes and stuffed tomatoes, and my grandmother had found relief for her chronic back problems sleeping on the futon in the guest room. I had vowed not to respond to any interruptions. But they phoned me at home several times and insisted the meeting was urgent and wouldn't take long and if I cared about the future of Latino Studies I should be there.

All heads are bent as if in prayer. The Anglo-American woman professor who heads American Culture, of which Latino Studies is a subunit, breaks the silence. If we don't appoint a director today, she says in a lamentful tone, the program will not be able to continue. The senior male faculty, obvious choices for the job, bow out quietly; they are going to be on leave during the coming year or have other pressing commitments. The eyes turn briefly to the non-tenured Chicana, Cubana, and Cubano professors, but we all realize it's not right to burden them with the job. And then I feel the eyes landing on me. "How about you, Ruth?" the chair says. My colleagues sitting next to me smile encouragingly, while a senior colleague, an Argentino who's held the job before, looks at me with sympathy. Before I can think of how to answer, my Chicana colleague whispers, "Do it. You'd be great. Don't let the program down."

Feels like her being Jewish + Cuban makes her less

Recalling how my university refused to hire me as a Latina, first because I'm Jewish, and second because Cubans no longer count as a needy Latin group, I feel an urge to take the job, to be Latina with a vengeance. I picture myself coming into the office wearing a Carmen Miranda headdress, or piling jewelry like thorns around my neck in the style of Frida Kahlo (who no one seems to remember, in this moment of Fridamania, was half-Jewish).

Latina according to others + wants to be viewed as Latina

I steal a glance at a colleague who is a puertorriqueña and an associate professor like me. She's knowledgeable and would be the perfect choice for director, I think, wondering why her name hasn't come up. I'm not sure what to make of her expression. Everyone's eyes are still upon me. I realize I haven't answered yet. "Maybe Frances and I could do it together, as codirectors" I say, not quite sure whether to phrase my sentence as a question or a hesitation. Frances pauses and then says, "That would be fine, but I'm going to be on leave in the fall." It hadn't occurred to me to say from the beginning that I wouldn't be able to take the job for the same reason. "Actually, that's my problem too," I now say. "I'm going to be on leave for the year." A sigh of despondency fills the room and I hear myself adding, "Well, maybe we could each give up a little of our leave time. For the sake of the program. But only if there's no one else who can do it."

As soon as I'm done speaking, our chairwoman brightly pops out of her seat and says, "Good, so you'll think about it?" I nod my head and Frances nods hers. It dawns on me that a maybe in this context is a roaring yes. The heavy air in the room, whose only window faces the computer center, seems to lighten, as though a breeze were blowing in from the Caribbean. People edge their seats back, waiting for the signal to leave. The decision has been made, it seems. Now I'm worrying about what I've gotten Frances into. Her baby, I realize, is only six months old. She needs to get writing done and so do I. We're both going to be on leave, just like the men, but somehow, in our case, that disclaimer seems to carry less weight.

The chairwoman calls the meeting to an end and rushes toward us and hugs us joyously at the same time like a bridal couple. She tells us she realizes it's unfair for us to give up our leave time and that she'll try her best to see if there's anyone else who can do it. Of course we both know that she won't find anyone else, but with our good Latina manners we politely thank her all the same.

And so begins a year in which two women supposedly on leave from their academic obligations give up several hours of their time a week trying to maintain the strengths of the program and introduce some new energy. Our first action is to change the name of the program from Latino Studies to Latina/Latino Studies, in obvious support for the Latinas in the program and for the many Latina writers and artists whose work we admire. This meets

with some criticism. We are told by the chairwoman that the names of programs can't be changed just like that; things need to be discussed and viewed from all sides and voted upon democratically and approved at various bureaucratic levels, but informally and provisionally we may use the new name.

We are not discouraged. We decided to start a series of Friday lectures by Latina and Latino faculty and students in order to build a sense of community. And we begin to think more ambitiously, of building a library of important books and essays, of offering funding to students to do research, of having essay contests, of inviting outside speakers, of organizing a retreat for the Latinas, but immediately we learn that the program is pathetically underfunded. And we learn it is underfunded because its intellectual existence needs constantly to be justified before the administration and our colleagues, some of whom feel—though they won't dare tell you in so many words—that the program's main purpose is to serve as a counseling service for those Latino and Latina students brave enough to set foot in the “Harvard of the Midwest.”

In the end, I never do get to sport the Carmen Miranda headdress or weigh my neck down with crucifying jewelry in the style of Frida Kahlo. Office life doesn't lend itself to zany exoticism or high drama. The only departure from the everyday drabness comes on the Day of the Dead, when a Chicano artist we have invited sets up an altar complete with candles, candy skulls, and pink and yellow paper cut-outs of dancing skeletons.

In the director's office I set up another altar in the corner in memory of my comadre Pancha, from Mexico. Her eyes, foggy from cooking tortillas on an outdoor fire, didn't see the car that killed her one morning as she ran across the highway to catch a bus. I use a bright red scarf with the imprint of the Virgin of Guadalupe as a background and place on the table a picture of my comadre, some bananas and bread, a lime wooden car driven by skeleton figures, and a can of Coke (*porque a mi comadre le gustaba su Coca*). I leave the altar up all year. As I sit talking to students or signing letters, I feel my comadre's smoke-filled eyes resting on me in that office with the gray metal desks and chairs, where the bookshelves stayed empty.

I am glad to be around the small but vibrant group of faculty and students—mostly Latinas—who care about the program. At the Friday seminars I find a community where I can hear thoughtful and sometimes heated debates about identity politics, feminist conflicts, stereotypes of the Latino community, and the geographies of difference between American Latinos and Latin Americans. As I listen, I realize that I've been hungry for such talk for a long time.

But it pains me to realize that some of those colleagues who participate most passionately only have visiting positions or lectureships. There is a Colombian professor who teaches Latino film courses and an Argentina professor who teaches courses about Latino health issues, and both of them are

Has
always
wanted
to prove
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is
Latina

always on the edge of their seats, waiting for their positions to be renegotiated from year to year. The Chilena professor who pioneered a course about U.S. Latinas and has taught for twenty years at the university as a lecturer in Spanish wonders whether she can rightfully identify as a Latina because of her middle-class background. How do I tell her that she became a Latina the day she arrived on this side of the border and was told her Latin American degree was worth nothing?

Yet I understand her predicament. I too am always wondering: do I, by calling myself a Latina, take away the “real” Latina identity of someone who needs to claim that identity for her very survival, self-preservation, and self-worth? Yet why should my colleague, or I, feel that our Latina identity is somehow optional? That we are temporary Latinas? Our Latina identity is not a garment that we choose to wear or discard at will. And yet we are often made to feel that way.

In this reading conflict of identity is not just due to being Jewish but also due to being Cuban

At stake is the question of who counts as a Latina or a Latino; in current affirmative action terms, you have to be Chicana or Chicano, or Puerto Rican, to qualify. Lately, two of my colleagues in Latina/Latino Studies, a Chicano (who is a convert to Judaism) and a puertorriqueña (who is married to a Chicano), have begun to put pressure on the university administration to redefine the meaning of Latino and Latina, so that fellowships can become available not just to Chicanos and puertorriqueños but to a broader range of needy students, including Guatemaltecos, Hondureños, Salvadoreños, Peruanos, and working-class Cubanos (of whom there are many from Hialeah and elsewhere who contradict the “success story” Cuban stereotype).

While I agree with my colleagues and support their efforts, I feel that out of respect for the struggles of Chicanos and puertorriqueños in this country, I, as a Cubana, cannot be the one to lobby for such expansions of the meaning of Latinidad. It would be an act of terrible presumption, an erasure of history. I must acknowledge the preferential treatment that was given to Cuban immigrants relative to other Latinos because of our symbolic capital during the Cold War as refugees from communism — although many Cubans will tell you that the only reason we got the red-carpet treatment was because the United States “owed it to us” for abandoning the Cuban insurgents at Bay of Pigs.

In truth, our individual Latino ethnic identities in this country have always been a function of our positions relative to the different histories of U.S. colonization in our home countries. Indeed, as the United States grows increasingly xenophobic, the border is being closed to Mexicans crossing over in search of honest work at the same time that the red carpet is being pulled from under the feet of Cubans still fleeing Fidel Castro. In recent years we have watched Cubans desperately seeking to cross over to the United States on

leaky rafts. What difference is there any more between Cuban *balseeros* and Mexican *mojados*? Clearly, as far as the dominant society and the U.S. government are concerned, we are all part of the same Latin horde that is threatening to overrun the country with the Spanish we can't seem to rub off our tongues and the dizzyingly hot salsas we both eat and dance.

Under these conditions, our identity as Latinas and Latinos will need to become stronger. Acknowledging a common Latinidad defined from within as a form of resistance, rather than from without as a form of negative stereotyping, is a step in a healing process. Our wounds arise from the genealogies of distrust and hatred that divide our various communities and that we have inherited along with the riches of our diverse cultures. Acknowledging a common Latinidad is a refusal to reproduce those genealogies that only pour salt on our wounds. It is a desire to give ourselves a chance to know one another as human beings and not as the absurd little boxes we are obliged to check off on the United States census. It is a process of learning to recognize the differences in our national origins and privileges while being able to identify compassionately with each other's sufferings and longings. All of us, in pain, loss, and grief, have carried the "other America" on our backs to these United States of America.

Latina/Latino Studies offers us a waiting room at the border where we can put down our string bags and suitcases and boxes, straighten our backs, and together stand tall, so we can cross over to the other side. Being involved in a program of Latina/Latino Studies I come to see just how many common experiences I share with others whose backgrounds, according to administrative categorizing, would seem to be different from mine. Many Latina/Latino students are the first in their families to be studying for an advanced degree, and they have a gentle, unassuming manner, a seriousness of purpose, and a profound vulnerability that touch me deeply. In their midst, I am reminded of my own beginnings, and my own struggle to become an educated woman.

When a Chicana student, in a shaky voice that is trying to hold back tears, tells me about how a professor insinuated that if he lent her his unpublished writings about a particular topic, she might plagiarize them, it is all I can do not to cry with her. I can't say to her, "Don't take it personally," because she's hurt to the bottom of her soul, and because I remember my own hurt when I was told by a professor, who thought she was being "objective," not to bother taking any more courses in philosophy because I lacked the appropriate "mental nature."

After our last Friday seminar is over, I am approached by a student I know only from seeing her at Latina/Latino Studies events. She stops me at the door and tells me she's been wanting to ask me how I feel about being in the

program. For the past year she has assumed I'm not Latina. I, on the other hand, have assumed that she is Latina. "I'm half Philippine, half Anglo," she tells me. "And I work on Puerto Rico. I'm dark, so I sort of look Puerto Rican." I tell her that I'm Cuban. "Oh, so you're a Latina?" she says, obviously surprised. I don't give her a chance to ask about my name or any of the other things that make my Latina identity suspect. I go ahead and complete my confession. "But I'm also Jewish," I say, and quickly add, "so I never feel totally authentic."

This encounter, coming at the end of a long year of administrative work for which I discovered I am definitely not suited, was both deeply troubling and illuminating. It made me wonder yet again: am I just a temporary Latina? A part-time Latina filling a space until the full-time Latinas can come on board? The student, assuming from my name or looks that I was a non-Latina co-directing a Latina/Latino Studies program, had, curiously, expected to share a common bond with me. And I, in turn, had made assumptions about the student's identity based on her looks and the fact of her participation in Latina/Latino Studies. Sadly, I had played into the racial and racist stereotyping game, and, worse, I had internalized the university administration's view of our program as a counseling service rather than as a serious academic discipline. It hadn't occurred to me that the student might not have been Latina because I expected that only "a real Latina" would have intellectual interests in Latina/Latino studies. Not only did I take it for granted that the student, being brown-skinned, was a Latina, I took it for granted that her color made her more authentically Latina than me.

Afterward it bothered me that I had felt obliged to apologize for being Jewish. Why should my being Jewish compromise my Latina identity? Haven't we gone beyond the authenticity contests of the past? Haven't we accepted hybridity and mixed identity and mestiza consciousness?

The problem is that current racial ideology in the United States classifies Jews as "whites" and Latinas/Latinos as "people of color." In the course of assimilating successfully into American society, Jews have become "whites," along with other European groups, like the Irish and the Italians, who earlier in the century were viewed as "nonwhite." Latinos and Latinas, on the other hand, have maintained, at once freely and forcibly, their claim on difference within American society, a difference that may include but is not limited to color. As a Cubana, and therefore a Latina, I'm presumably a person of color. Yet I'm equivocally of color, because middle-class Cubans of the first emigrant wave are thought to have "made it" enough to become "white." But as a Jew, certainly, aren't I a white woman? I'm equivocally white, too, it turns out, especially if I listen to those Jewish critics who invoke the recent historical memory of our racial otherness as people of color, lest we forget too quickly

how we were viewed only half a century ago, and how, indeed, we are still viewed by neo-Nazi groups today.

All of this is very ironic for me, because the reason I came to be born in Cuba is that my grandparents could not enter the United States in the 1920s because of racist quotas that sought to curtail Jewish immigration. Seventy years ago, my grandparents were not “white enough” to be granted entrance into the United States. Yet, in Cuba, where the turn-of-the-century white ruling class worried about the rise of the black population on the island, they were welcomed as white Europeans. Being white is always relative to how the “dark other” is constructed. Now, two generations later, having come to the United States with symbolic capital as a Cuban refugee from communism, I am “too white” and “too Jewish” to be authentically Latina.

I remember how a Jewish American colleague laughed and sarcastically said *Mazal Tov* to me when he heard I’d become codirector of Latino Studies. American Jews always have trouble accepting the Cuban part of my identity. They think it’s a joke. They can’t believe it’s real. They want me to just be Jewish and be done with it. Not to complicate things. To finally admit to my “essential” identity and stop kidding myself about being Latina. Yet another ostensibly well-meaning but much more vicious assumption was voiced by a different Jewish American colleague, who said I was just like her, and that I was too successful to be a Latina — as if not being successful is the definition of a Latina!

It is precisely in such situations, which seek to turn me into a temporary Latina, when I most fiercely take hold of my Latina identity with all the determination of the Virgin of Guadalupe crushing the ugly snake underfoot. The ad of my childhood was “You don’t have to be Jewish to like rye bread.” So who says you have to be Catholic or Mexican to invoke *La Guadalupe*? I say: Any success I’ve had has come not in spite of my being Latina but because I am Latina — a Latina who grew up with a belly filled with black beans and rice, a Latina whose prayers, when she remembers to say them, for the gifts of light, bread, and wine, are always uttered in Hebrew with the cadences of the Spanish her banished Sephardic ancestors stubbornly kept speaking, even in their exile.

IS it common for latina/latino
Jews for their identities to be
viewed at odds or that one ^{suppose of it} negates
the other depending on the context?